

ADAMCARSEDIT-1

We're speaking with Adam Thomas from Marimbula, and he's a classic car restorer, world traveller. And speaking of world travel, we met in Amsterdam with your wife, your lovely wife, and I showed you around Amsterdam a bit, and you've definitely been on the travel bug for the past few years. You've been hitting the world, and tell us about some of your favourite places.

Yeah, well, I'd like to go back to Amsterdam, actually. We were going down the Rhine. We started at Amsterdam going down to Budapest.

When we met you, Jeff, it was quite funny because we were recommended to come and see you. Now, we were told that you were staying with and living with Big Frank, Big Frankie. So can you tell me and your listeners a little bit about Big Frank and who he used to look after and how famous he was? Yes, he's a very famous person in Amsterdam.

He's part of the Rolling Stones entourage. He's a very big music person. He was the former manager of the Hard Rock Cafe in Amsterdam, back in the 90s, where he was also the resident DJ.

So he got to meet a lot of the big stars who used to hang out there, and he became very close friends with Mick Jagger and Keith Richards in particular. And now he's on the entourage in Europe when the Rolling Stones tour, he always has a room provided for him in all the destinations in Europe to actually hang out with the Stones. And Big Frank is a real legend in the music industry in Europe and worldwide, actually.

And when I stayed in Amsterdam, I lived at his place for many, many years and rented a room from him there. And he is just a fantastic guy to hang around and a real legend of Amsterdam. And it was great showing you and your wife around because I've been in Amsterdam for 24 years and we got to see a bit of the real Amsterdam where Frankie lives in the Jordaan area.

You know, we took a walk and tell us about your experience of that area. Well, you know, Belinda and I were looking probably forward to Amsterdam, the lakes, before we got there. But we actually had a ball and I suppose that's thanks to you, Geoff.

We always knew that there was going to be the Red Light District and we did, you know, obviously we knew that there was going to be a lot of marijuana being smoked and cafes, etc. But, you know, we did see a lot of the other side as well. We went to the most amazing restaurant and we went to that big hall at the end over the bridge where they had the markets.

Oh, yes, the food hall. The food hall. Yes, it's incredible.

And then you took us to, you know, all these other parts. Belinda and I were, you know, we were just fascinated. Even just the way that you walk around that place in the evening and how you've

got to cross the bridges and just how everybody's laid back, they're all sitting outside the cafe.

And then you took us to that lovely pub. And I think the weather is quite kind as well. But we were sitting there at the pub overlooking the river in front of us and the sun was shining right through.

And we had a few drinks and we were chatting and it was really, really amazing. I just loved Amsterdam and we actually liked it that much that we'd probably go back and do something. Well, actually, we are going back.

We're going back to do the Netherlands, Scandinavia and Norway, Sweden, Denmark in four weeks. So we're really looking forward to that. We're flying into London and then we're going to hire a car and go out to the Cotswolds.

It's been three or four days out there and then we're going to, you know, do what I just mentioned. I've always wanted, I don't know why it is, but I've always wanted to go and see Norway. And I've seen the, you know, the Northern Lights on video and what have you.

And I probably won't see it this time, but just the area, the mountains and how pretty it is. It's something that I've always wanted to see before I go. And I'm planning on not going anywhere anytime soon, Jeff, but who knows? Yes, that's the thing about travel.

When these things are on your bucket list, it's really fabulous to go and actually experience it when you get the opportunity. And Norway and Sweden are wonderful. I lived in Sweden for eight years and I know the whole area of Norway and Sweden and Finland and Iceland and Denmark.

And it's just a magnificent place to visit and I'd highly recommend that. And it's really been great talking to you, Adam, on the program. And can you give us just a couple of your really amazing tips for people who are heading to Europe? What would be your maybe top three places that really stand out for you? Find the person that's got the most amount of money and wait for them to put their bag down, grab that and run as fast as you can.

Because you're going to need it because your dollar doesn't go real fast when you get there, I can tell you. Exactly. I shouldn't say that even joking, but it is a bit of a shock when you convert your Australian dollar to euro.

I mean, I don't know. I'd have to chat to my wife about that, but I've been to some wonderful places. We do like the south of France around Nice and Es and Monaco.

Although Monaco seems to be a bit of a glamorous area and probably overpriced. But I do like the south of France, Switzerland. We got a scenic train through Switzerland.

We started in just trying to think where it was. It was one of those scenic trains that had a glass ceiling all over the top and on the walls. And, you know, they serve you champagne and wine and, you know, and you just go.

So I think we started at Basel. Basel, yeah. And then we went all the way right through Montréal, Montreux, sorry.

Montreux, yes. Where they have the jazz festival, actually. That's right.

Yeah, yeah. And then we stopped at Interlaken and we stopped at all these wonderful places and hopped off. We stayed the night, had a look around.

We actually stayed two nights at Interlaken and it was gorgeous there. And then we went all the way right down to the north of Italy at Lake Como. It's funny, you know, for your listeners, and I'm sure they can picture this.

You know how you see in Switzerland, you've got all these cows with the bells around their neck. And they're walking through all these beautiful green pastures and all these wonderful mountains with snow on the top of them. And you think, that's not, that's all superimposed.

It doesn't look like that. Well, I can tell you, and I'm sure you're aware of this, Geoff, it does look like that. And it's actually better in real life.

And the cows do have bells around their neck. And it is amazing. And, you know, I was just talking to Frank.

Frank J. Holden yesterday and his wife Michelle about it. And they said that's something that they would love to do. And, you know, we explained to them how we did it.

And the scenic train, I think, was about \$1,800. And you get like a three week pass or a four week pass or however long you want. And you can just hop on and hop off as you please.

But it was, that was one thing that I recommend that everybody does. The only other one thing that I really liked is we hopped on a boat called the Azamara. It's an American boat.

And it only holds about 800 passengers. And we did Greece Intensive, they called it. And it just went to all these different areas in Greece.

It started in Athens, started in Spain, I think. And it finished in Athens. I can't remember the vice versa, but it went to all these lovely areas in all the islands, in Greek islands.

And that was certainly worth seeing. It was certainly worth seeing. The only one other thing I will say is Malta.

The older part of Malta, that was beautiful. It was actually stunning. And a lot cheaper than Italy, it seemed to be something that I was untouched.

It was really, it was not busy. And the only other place that we really, really liked was in Bordeaux in France. Have you been there, Geoff? Yes, I have.

And I've had sampled a little bit of the local product. I sampled a lot of the local product. Half of it was a blur.

I shouldn't say that on the day. Well, from five o'clock in the evening onwards anyway. Oh, that's right.

And well, especially in France. So it's very traditional to have a drink in the afternoon. And if you're not used to it, it's a bit tough to keep up with it.

But absolutely beautiful Bordeaux. It's just stunning. And the people are very friendly.

And it's out of Paris. It's not as touristy. It is touristy, but it's much more natural and local.

And the local people are very beautiful there. Very nice. Well, yeah, we actually spent three or four days there.

It was actually quite nice. And what we did was we stayed in the city in the area called the Gabrielle area. I remember it really well.

And then they had the water reflection pond it's called. And a fellow by the name of Bob Dunnett, quite a good friend of mine. He's been a big influence on me.

He's been like a father figure to me. I met Bob many years ago. He actually owns, well, I can say this.

I'm sure he doesn't mind. He owns 170 acres next door to Olivia Newton John's old property in Byron Bay. And now Twiggy Forest owns that.

He purchased it and Bob owns the large property next door. And I think Bob's property is better than Olivia or Twiggy's Forest's property. I think it's in a better location and I think it's a better area.

But he was the one that said to me, Adam, you need to go to Bordeaux and you need to go and stay in the Gabrielle area and have a look there and go to the reflection pond and do a few day trips out to the wineries. And we did and we absolutely loved it. But once again, I think we went at the right time of the year and I think the weather played a big part in that too.

I think it would be completely different if you went there in winter and the weather wasn't kind. That's right. Yes, it's good all year round.

But if you get those beautiful Bordeaux summer or spring days, it's just superb, absolutely superb. Well, Adam, it's been fantastic talking to you. It's Adam Thomas in Marimbula and it's a beautiful area, the Sapphire Coast.

And thank you very much, Adam, for sharing your experiences with you and your wife Belinda on

your world travels. And I'm sure you have a lot more fabulous places to visit and maybe you can do a few more reports back to us here on Travel Radio Australia in the future. Yeah, I'm happy to do that.

And I probably, well, now that I've done this, it would be nice for you to probably chat to Frankie J and get him on board. And I'm sure he's got some wonderful stories. And I know you guys have a connection back in, you know, back 1990, 1978? 1978 was in... Oh, there you go.

Yes, young New South Wales. I was a very young announcer on radio there. And I picked him up in a ute.

He was performing a show for 2LF, actually, the radio station. And he and I were rolling around in the back of the station ute with his luggage and his sound equipment. And it was an interesting time.

What was that before the gig or after the gig? It was before the gig, actually. And we picked him up from the airport to do the gig in the station ute. So, actually, we couldn't get the station car, so we could only get hold of a ute.

And I said, when I saw him at the airport, listen, mate, it's going to have to be the back of the ute because the whole front is packed out. And he said, yeah, no worries, mate, sounds great. So it was an amazing experience.

I think he's pretty damn well frank. I'm sure he'd be the same sort of guy that would be happy to get in the back now. Oh, it was great.

It was good fun. And we had a real laugh and nice connection. He did a great show, as always.

You know, Frankie J is an amazing performer. And we really look forward to talking to him here on Travel Radio Australia in the future. Yeah.

Well, thanks for having me. I just want to ask you one question. I did hear a little rumor, or not a rumor, but I was told at the time that big Frank used to look after Lady Gaga and also Justin Deaver when he used to come to town in Amsterdam area or whatever as well.

Is that true? Yes, it is true, actually. Frank acts as Lady Gaga's unofficial bodyguard when she is there. She does have her own bodyguard, but he is the local Amsterdam bodyguard.

So he joins her when she walks around. She actually has a... She walks around with a big hat and sunglasses, and she has a bit of anonymity that way. But the thing is that he bought her... She wanted a tattoo in Amsterdam, and big Frankie took her to his friend's tattoo parlor in the red light district, and she got a tattoo of an anchor on her... just below her right breast on her rib.

She's got a little anchor tattoo as a memory of Amsterdam, and big Frankie organised all that. So

he's pretty influential with these big stars, and they really trust him. And the fact that he's 6'6", and he's not called big Frankie for nothing is... I did hear that, and I was told all these stories before I met you, and they did say, look, you're a lovely guy, and you'll spend a bit of time with us.

And I do remember going all through the canals with you, and we had a few beers while we were being... We had an amazing time. We really did. Yeah, we were on the Boat Amsterdam trip, actually.

We went out on the boat, which is just an amazing experience, and that's really cheap. That's only about 15 or 20 euro a person, and you get drinks included. It's incredible.

It's a whole hour rolling around Amsterdam on the canals on a beautiful boat, which is... It was only about 20 people on the boat, and it's open, and it's gorgeous, and so I'd highly recommend that too. And I think you would too, because it's just an amazing experience there. Yeah, it was great.

And we're actually heading back to Amsterdam soon too. That'll be where we're going in three or four weeks. So I'm not going to do all the things again, but I'll tell you what I am going to do.

Marimbula is very well known for its oysters. Yes. Sydney Rock Oysters, which that's what they are.

They're Sydney Rock Oysters, but they're grown down here in the Sapphire Coast. They go all over the world. They go to a lot of the... Alex Perry's restaurant, Margaret, and all these wonderful restaurants up at Vanister's, which is Rick Stein's restaurant.

All our oysters go there, but I must say the best oyster I ever had in my life was in that market over the bridge there that we went to that you took us to. Oh, right. And then even Belinda, my wife, because they weren't a kinky oyster.

They were a beautiful oyster. They were big, and they were really nice. And then when we went out for dinner that night, I think it was when we were having Chinese, of all things, in Amsterdam, but we were told that it was a fantastic restaurant and we should go there.

We ordered the oysters again because we found out they were coming from the same place, which was up the river in France. And I said to Belinda, we just need to have as many of these as we can because I just don't think we're ever going to get them again. That's right.

Well, the Netherlands is renowned for its seafood as well. The seafood around the Netherlands is incredible. And, of course, they have the herring and all that sort of stuff that they eat raw.

I'm not really into that, but apparently it's gorgeous. But, yeah, it's a great place. Well, thanks so much, Adam, for being on the programme.

And we look forward to more reports from you and Belinda in your world travels on Travel Radio Australia. Thanks, Geoff. Thanks for inviting me on.

And I hope your listeners visit some of these places and experience the wonderful times that we've had. Great. Thanks, Adam, for being part of the programme.

All right, mate. Thanks, Adam.